Does the Activation Function Matter? ReLU vs LeakyReLU vs tanh for ECG Diagnosis

Dhairya Bhatia

October 2026

In short

We trained the same ECG model three times, changing only one part: the **activation function**. The three choices were ReLU, LeakyReLU and tanh.

- **ReLU and LeakyReLU work equally well.** Both score 0.922.
- **tanh is a little worse.** It scores 0.919 and learns more slowly at the start.
- **All three learn the same thing.** They rely on the shape of each heartbeat, not on the order of beats.

Bottom line: keep ReLU. LeakyReLU gives no benefit here, and tanh costs a little accuracy.

1. What we tested

The task. The model reads a 10-second, 12-lead ECG from the PTB-XL dataset and answers five yes/no questions: is the ECG normal (NORM), does it show a heart attack (MI), ST/T changes (STTC), a conduction problem (CD) or thickened heart muscle (HYP)?

The model. A 1D ResNet, a common type of neural network for signals. It has 17 places where it applies an activation function. An activation function decides what each part of the network passes on:

Activation	What it does with a value
ReLU	Keeps positive values, turns negative values into 0
LeakyReLU	Keeps positive values, shrinks negative values to 1% instead of 0
tanh	Squashes every value into the range −1 to 1, along a smooth S-shaped curve

Everything else stayed the same: data, training settings, 30 passes over the data, and 3 runs per model with different random seeds.

How we score. We use **AUROC**. Take one ECG that has a condition and one that doesn't. AUROC is how often the model gives the first one a higher score. 1.0 is perfect and 0.5 is guessing. "Macro" is the average over the five conditions.

The shuffle test. To see *what* each model relies on, we cut each test ECG into equal pieces, shuffle the pieces and measure how much the score drops. A heartbeat lasts about 1 second, so:

- shuffling **1-second pieces** mixes up the order of whole beats, and
- shuffling **0.2-second pieces** breaks each beat apart.

A "control" makes the same cuts but keeps the pieces in order. This tells us how much of the drop comes from the cuts themselves rather than from losing the order.

2. Accuracy

Condition	ReLU	LeakyReLU	tanh
NORM	0.944	0.944	0.943
MI	0.922	0.919	0.916
STTC	0.932	0.934	0.933
CD	0.916	0.916	0.915
HYP	0.896	0.895	0.890
Macro	**0.922 ± 0.001**	**0.922 ± 0.002**	**0.919 ± 0.002**

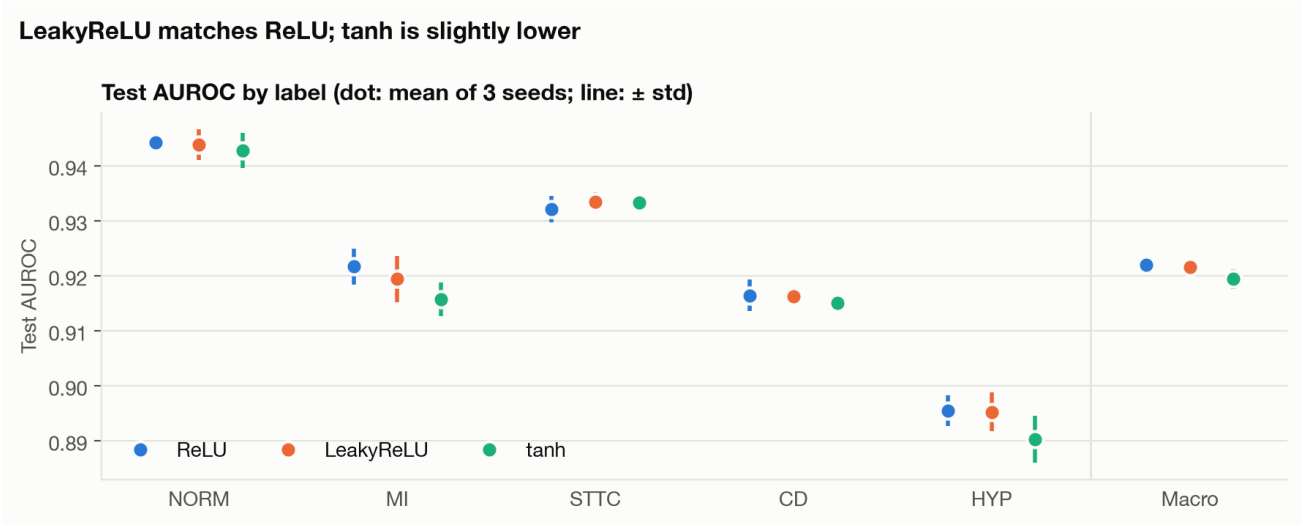


Figure 1: Test AUROC for each condition and activation. Dots are the average of 3 runs; lines show the spread.

- **LeakyReLU is the same as ReLU.** No condition differs by more than 0.003, which is about how much the score moves between runs anyway.
- **tanh is 0.003 lower overall,** mostly on MI and HYP (0.006 lower on each). The gap is small but consistent: every tanh run scored below every ReLU run on the validation set.

Why doesn't LeakyReLU help? LeakyReLU was invented to fix a ReLU problem: parts of a network can get stuck outputting 0 and stop learning. But this model already rescales its values (batch normalization) before every activation, which mostly prevents that problem. So there is little for LeakyReLU to fix.

3. Training

All three models reach almost the same training loss. The difference is in the validation score:

- **tanh starts slower.** In the first 10 passes its validation score is clearly behind the other two.
- **All three peak around pass 15–20** (best pass on average: ReLU 16.7, LeakyReLU 18.0, tanh 18.3) and then get slightly worse as they start to memorize the training data. We keep the best version of each.

4. What the models rely on

The three lines almost overlap, so all three models behave the same way:

- **Shuffling whole beats barely matters.** With 1-second pieces the score drops by only 0.003–0.005.
- **Breaking beats apart matters a lot.** With 0.2-second pieces the score drops by 0.08–0.09, much more than the control (0.03–0.04).

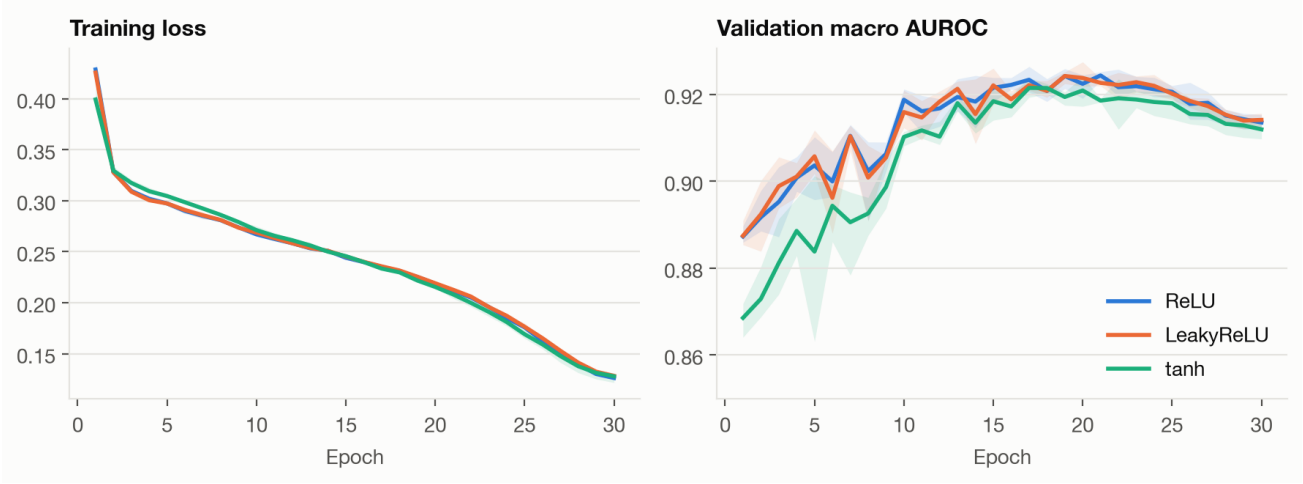


Figure 2: Training loss and validation score after each pass over the data (line: average of 3 runs; band: lowest to highest).

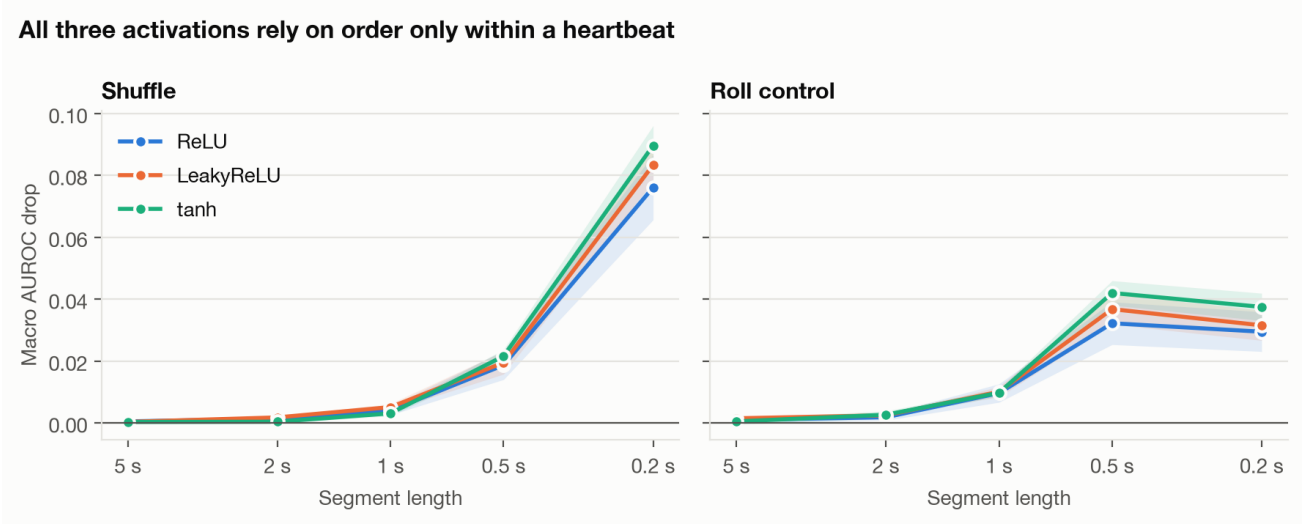


Figure 3: Score drop when the ECG is shuffled (left) or only cut (right), for each piece length.

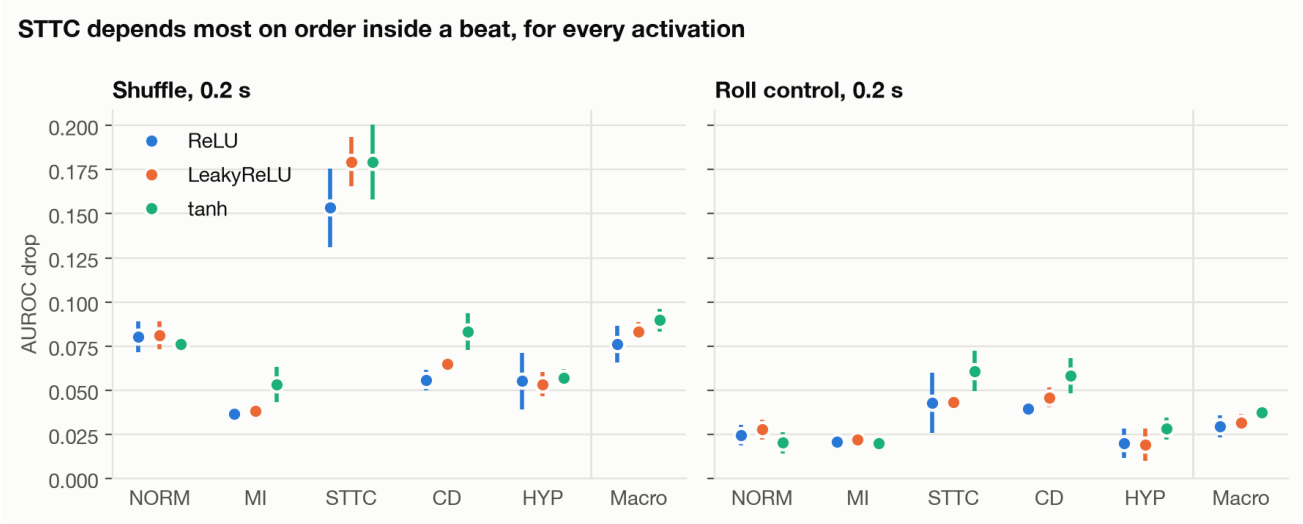


Figure 4: Score drop for each condition with 0.2-second pieces.

So every model looks at the **shape inside each heartbeat**, not at the rhythm between beats.

ST/T changes (STTC) are hit hardest in every model (a drop of 0.15–0.18). That makes sense: spotting an ST/T change means knowing what comes right after the main spike of the beat, which is exactly what shuffling destroys.

LeakyReLU and tanh are slightly *more* affected by 0.2-second shuffling than ReLU (0.083 and 0.090 vs 0.076). That gap is about the size of the run-to-run spread, so with only 3 runs we can't be sure it is real.

	ReLU	LeakyReLU	tanh
Drop, 1-second shuffle	0.004	0.005	0.003
Drop, 0.2-second shuffle	0.076	0.083	0.090
Drop, 0.2-second control	0.030	0.032	0.038
Effect of order inside a beat (shuffle − control)	0.047	0.052	0.052
STTC drop, 0.2-second shuffle	0.153	0.179	0.179

5. Conclusion

Question	Answer
Does LeakyReLU improve accuracy?	No, it ties with ReLU.
Does tanh improve accuracy?	No, it is slightly worse (–0.003) and learns more slowly at first.
Does the activation change what the model relies on?	No. All three use beat shape, not beat order.
Which should we use?	ReLU: the simplest choice, and as accurate as either alternative.

Limits. Each model was trained only 3 times, so small differences (under about 0.005) may be noise. We tested one model design at one recording rate (100 samples per second), with the default LeakyReLU setting (1%). A bigger LeakyReLU setting such as 10% could behave differently.

Where to find everything.

- Settings: `configs/leaky_relu.yaml`, `configs/tanh.yaml`
- Results: `runs/resnet1d_leaky_relu/`, `runs/resnet1d_tanh/`
- All numbers in one table: `figures/activation_metrics.csv`
- Figures: made by `scripts/plot_results.py`
- Cluster logs: `logs/train_leaky_relu_11184009.log`, `logs/train_tanh_11184010.log`